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GovErNing human rights through partnErShIpS:
rights at the interface of multistakeholder governance & international law

Appendix 1:

Report on the Design and Development of the GENESIS Database on Multistakeholder Partnerships for Sustainable Development

Work Package 4 – GENESIS Project

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Abstract

This publication presents the design and development of the Database on Multistakeholder Partnerships (MSPs) for Sustainable Development of the ERC-funded GENESIS research project. This Database was created to map existing projects contributing to the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and empirically assess the participation and involvement of MSPs in such projects. The Database was constructed to support Work Package 4 of the GENESIS project, which investigates how MSPs engage with international human rights standards in delivering collective goods and services associated with the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Drawing primarily on the UN DESA SDG Partnerships Platform and complemented by additional sources, the dataset compiles 3,977 projects and applies a structured three-step Data Scraping Protocol to identify partnerships that qualify as MSPs—defined as networked arrangements involving public, private, and civil society actors—and that operate as long-term initiatives focused on SDGs 2 (food), 3 (health), 4 (education), or 6 (water). Using this method, 160 projects implemented by MSPs were identified for further analysis in this research project. However, the complete dataset of projects (either implemented by MSPs or other actors) is published open access to ensure it meets the data management FAIR criteria: findable, accessible, interoperable, and reusable. The resulting workbook offers a systematically curated set of projects, initiatives and partnerships operating in these four SDG domains and serves as a foundational resource for examining their governance practices, accountability gaps, and engagement with human rights norms, while also providing a versatile research tool for broader studies.

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1. Introduction

This report outlines the design, development, and functioning of the Database on Multistakeholder Partnerships (MSPs) engaged in sustainable development activities within the framework of the United Nations 2030 Agenda and its Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). The database was built as part of a research project that seeks to empirically and systematically analyse MSPs by examining individual cases of partnerships that operate in the domains of food (SDG 2), health (SDG 3), education (SDG 4), and water (SDG 6).

This research is part of a larger project funded by an ERC Starting Grant titled “GovErNing human rights through partnErShIpS: rights at the interface of multistakeholder governance & international law” (GENESIS). The overarching goal of the GENESIS project is to study the complex interactions between the paradigm of multilateralism, governed primarily by inter-state relations, and the paradigm of multistakeholderism, spearheaded by MSPs. This project understands MSPs as collaborative alliances involving public actors, private actors (corporations, philanthropy, or financial institutions), and civil society organizations (CSO), which come together voluntarily under a networked arrangement. According to Gray & Purdy, “when three or more types of stakeholders are engaged we refer to these partnerships as multistakeholder partnerships” (2018, p. 3). Although multiple definitions of MSPs exist in the literature, these are “generally defined as initiatives where public-interest entities, private sector companies, (NGOs) and/or civic society organizations enter into an alliance to achieve a common practical purpose, pool core competencies, and share risks, responsibilities, resources, costs and benefits” (Utting & Zammit, 2009, p. 40 cited by Gray & Purdy, 2018, p. 3). MSPs have become increasingly central to sustainable development, aiming to deliver collective goods that are simultaneously recognized as human rights under international law.

The database described in this report offers a structured and comprehensive list of projects contributing to sustainable development, specifically to one of the four SDGs covered by this research: food, health, education, and/or water. From the list of projects in this dataset, we identified the ones that were being conducted by MSPs and, with a Data Scraping Protocol, extracted from the Database a set of *Multistakeholder Partnerships for Sustainable Development*. This set of MSPs will serve as the main input and empirical foundation for the fourth Working Package (WP4) of the GENESIS project, which aims to investigate whether and how these partnerships engage with international human rights standards in their operations.

Beyond the identification of MSPs from the list of sustainable development projects, this publication offers an organized and curated set of data on 3,977 projects conducted by different types of actors, including MSPs, but also corporate (business to business) partnerships, public-private partnerships, CSO platforms, among others. This research output may be used in other research and has applicability across the different disciplines that study human rights and sustainable development. Although the GENESIS project targets four specific SDGs, the database contains projects that may simultaneously contribute to multiple SDGs and, therefore, initiatives covering other SDGs may also be found here. This may result useful for research projects covering other development sectors.

1.1. Background and research framework

Multistakeholderism has gained prominence in the field of sustainable development as a new global governance model (Pattberg & Widerberg, 2016; Beisheim & Simon, 2016; Berman, 2017a) perceived to be more flexible and better resourced for delivering effective results and attaining development goals, in contrast to the traditional intergovernmental system of multilateralism. The promised effectiveness of this paradigm has been questioned and is still a matter of debate among scholars and policy-makers, for new governance gaps have emerged in attempting to counter the limitations of the inter-state system of global governance and development (Scholte, 2020; Erdem Türkelli, 2021). Nevertheless, MSPs continue to proliferate as key actors in international affairs and have been particularly encouraged under the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

These partnerships bring together different actors on a voluntary basis to coordinate, fund and implement development projects across the globe. However, they are loosely regulated under international law and their accountability and compliance with legal standards remains discretionary and largely unclear (Benner et al., 2004; Hale & Mauzerall, 2004; Bäckstrand, 2006; Erdem Türkelli, 2021). MSPs operate in a regulatory grey area, with no dedicated international legal framework defining their responsibilities or guiding their operations. This raises important questions about whether MSPs abide by international norms, particularly human rights standards, considering that some of the SDGs they cover are also human rights, and the beneficiaries they target are, above all, rights-holders. The complexity is further compounded by the hybrid nature of MSPs (Benish & Mattei, 2020), whose members include both state and non-state actors with different obligations under international human rights law.

Although MSPs coexist with multilateral dynamics at the national, regional and global levels, from an academic standpoint, the interface between multilateralism and multistakeholderism remains both conceptually and empirically underexplored. There is limited academic work on MSPs from a human rights perspective, let alone from multidisciplinary approaches. The GENESIS project addresses this gap and its WP4, in particular, responds to the need for an empirical and systematic analyses on this new governance model, seeking to understand how MSPs operate and whether they engage with human rights norms in practice.

The Database on Multistakeholder Partnerships for Sustainable Development serves as the starting point of this empirical inquiry. This dataset maps existing projects contributing to sustainable development and identifies the ones that are being implemented by MSPs to subsequently assess their work at the operational level. The data contained in this database derives primarily from an online platform of the United Nations (UN) that has evolved over the years to compile and track collective initiatives that support sustainable development objectives.

Firstly, the Department of Economic and Social Affairs (UN DESA) established an online database for partnerships in 2004 called the “United Nations Partnerships Database” (Beisheim & Simon, 2016, p. 7), which was created following the 2002 World Summit on Sustainable Development (WSSD) in Johannesburg. This database aimed to track and promote transparency for Type II Partnerships through an online registry for voluntary commitments and partnerships contributing to sustainable development (Andonova & Levy, 2003; Hale & Mauzerall, 2004).

Secondly, as the 2030 Agenda was being developed between 2012 and 2015, this database was updated and reoriented to align with the SDGs. In September 2015, UN DESA relaunched the database under a new name: “Partnerships for SDGs Online Platform” (PD4SDGs). This was a more interactive open platform for voluntary commitments and MSPs supporting the newly adopted agenda and its main goals and targets.

Finally, in 2022 the platform was migrated to the portal of the Division for Sustainable Development Goals (DSDG) in UN DESA, and renamed once more. The so-called “SDG Actions Platform”, still active today, works as a broader registry not just for partnerships, but for ‘actions’ on sustainable development, which encompasses projects, voluntary policies, commitments, campaigns, and other initiatives that support the SDGs. According to the DSDG website, governments and other actors must self-register their policies or initiatives in this portal by filling out a form sharing key information about their actions.

The Database presented in this report was built primarily from the data available on this UN Platform, whose latest version has a much wider scope than the original 2004 version, which was devoted exclusively to partnerships. Consequently, the GENESIS research team had to assess each individual project registered on the Platform under SDGs 2, 3, 4, and 6, in order to identify those actually carried out by partnerships, and retrieve a list of MSPs therefrom. In addition to the UN DESA SDG Actions Platform, other sources were consulted to complement the GENESIS Database and ensure that relevant MSPs (perhaps not registered in UN DESA) were also included in the study.

1.2. Purpose and scope of the report

This narrative report documents the process through which the GENESIS Database was designed and developed to compile comprehensive and structured information on sustainable development projects. The curated data was systematized into an Excel spreadsheet and is also made available in XML, CSV, and HTML formats to maximize interoperability and usability across platforms. The focus of this research output is on partnerships that exhibit a multistakeholder nature —defined here as those involving at least one actor from the public, private, and civil society sectors. These MSPs were identified and singled out from the broader dataset.

Users of the dataset can expect to find that most projects operate in the areas of food (SDG 2), health (SDG 3), education (SDG 4), and water (SDG 6), even if some initiatives span multiple sectors and can therefore be linked to other SDGs. The rationale behind the prioritization of these four SDGs is their strong connection to the core content of key Economic, Social, and Cultural Rights (ESCR). MSPs working in these areas often provide collective goods and services that were traditionally delivered by states in line with the international human rights obligations. In recent years, however, MSPs have increasingly occupied this operational space, raising important questions about how the uptake human rights standards. The four selected SDGs are therefore particularly relevant and representative for observing MSP behaviour of MSPs in relation to ESCRs.

Under this chosen scope, and given this conceptual and practical intersection between sustainable development activities and ESCRs, the GENESIS team extracted all projects from the UN DESA SDG Actions Platform that self-reported contributions to SDGs 2, 3, 4, and 6. Whether these SDGs represented the primary focus of each project was subsequently evaluated by the research team and recorded through the Data Scraping Protocol outlined in Section 3.

2. Data collection process

The data collection process began by accessing the United Nations' SDG Goals website, particularly the UN DESA SDG Actions Platform. Using a web scraping method, project listings under SDG 2 (Zero Hunger), SDG 3 (Good Health and Well-being), SDG 4 (Quality Education), and SDG 6 (Clean Water and Sanitation) were extracted and compiled.

Two data analysts were hired to carry out the web scraping using Python, a programming language, and Visual Studio, an integrated development environment. A custom script accessed each individual project entry and extracted relevant information, including project name, associated SDG codes, project description, list of partners, among other data. This information was initially stored in CSV format, and subsequently converted into both Excel and Numbers formats for analysis and archiving. The initial data extraction and compilation process was finalized in June 2024.

Once the full dataset was converted into the Excel spreadsheet, three research assistants¹ were hired consecutively to analyse and assess each project. Based on the information of extracted from the UN DESA Platform, as well as further review of each project's website and public documents, the team classified each entry according to the scope of the research project using the Protocol detailed in Section 3. In parallel to this process, in January 2025, all listed projects were reviewed again for accuracy, and any new entries added to the UN Platform since 27 June 2024 were incorporated into the Excel file.

Because self-registration on the UN DESA Platform is open and voluntary, some MSPs (though sometimes highly relevant and well-known within their respective sectors), may not have been listed therein. Consequently, between 2 July and 31 October 2025, the Database was further complemented with partnerships identified

¹ Fatih Avci, Ysaline Reid, and Lina Höltje.

through alternative sources of information, including academic literature, documentation from the World Economic Forum (WEF), the High-Level Political Forum on Sustainable Development (HLPF), among others². Although the cut-off date for the inclusion of new projects into the Database was 31 October 2025, the data was further curated, and the accompanying documents and formats were finalized on 15 December 2025.

2.1. Database architecture: design and structure

The database was designed as a structured spreadsheet to allow for the systematic collection and analysis of projects and partnerships for sustainable development. The spreadsheet layout is both functional and user-friendly, enabling efficient navigation, filtering, and extraction of relevant data. Each row in the database corresponds to a single project entry, while each column contains a specific variable with information associated with that entry. The columns are organized as follows:

- Project Number
- Project SDGs
- Project Name
- Source
- Status
- Type of Partnership
- Type of Project
- SDG Scope
- Description
- Start Date
- End Date
- Partners
- Info Link
- Project Link

Each of these columns is explained in detail in Appendix 2: Methodological Sheet. All of these columns —except for the variables “Status”, “Type of Partnership”, “Type of Project” and “SDG Scope”— contain information derived from the UN DESA SDG Actions Platform or the alternative source from where each project was pulled. All this information is public and available in the webpage of each project in the UN DESA Platform (project link) or in the project’s own website (info link). Instead, the four variables mentioned above were added by the researcher to the Database, and together they constitute the step-by-step procedure of the Data Scraping Protocol applied to classify the projects according to the scope of the study.

In addition to these columns, contact name and email from the person leading each project was publicly available in the UN DESA SDG Actions Platform and was collected during the web scraping process. However, for personal data protection reasons, this information was removed from the GENESIS Database and will not be published as part of this research output.

3. Protocol for case selection

As noted above, the MSP database contains information on partnerships operating across all 17 SDGs. However, to identify the subset of projects relevant to this investigation, that is, those implemented by MSPs and working on one of the four SDGs targeted by the project, an internal Data Scraping Protocol was applied for case

² The full list of consulted sources is detailed in Appendix 2: Methodological Sheet.

selection. This protocol enabled the identification of partnerships that met three predefined criteria, each one contained in a separate column: “Type of Partnership”, “Type of Project” and “SDG Scope”. The “Status” column that appears right before these three shows whether a project entry has met the three criteria of the protocol and “Checked-In” for the subsequent stages of the research, or alternatively, “Checked-Out” if failing to meet the criteria in these three variables.

This protocol serves to single out the datapoints falling within the scope of WP4 of the GENESIS project, while it filters out other types of initiatives outside the research scope. It was originally built for previous research on a version developed by Dr. Gamze Erdem Türkelli for a pilot database focused exclusively on education (SDG 4). For the GENESIS project, this protocol was revised, refined and expanded to include SDGs 2, 3, and 6 for the empirical analysis conducted in WP4.

The case selection protocol followed a traffic light system (green–yellow–red) that was implemented through a structured three-step process:

Step I: Type of Partnership

Partnerships classified as MSPs were marked green and the label ‘MSP’ was annotated in the corresponding cell. All other types of partnerships, including public-private, corporate-CSO, public-public, corporate-only, or any other type of arrangements were marked red and excluded from further analysis. If the nature of the partnership was unclear, the datapoint was temporarily marked yellow and after further collective revision within the research team, it would ultimately be marked either green or red. Any entry marked red at this stage was automatically discarded from Steps II and III, which were then greyed out and marked with a hyphen³.

Step II: Type of Project

Projects identified as long-term initiatives (‘INI’) —structured programs or platforms intended to operate over time— were marked green. Short-term projects (‘PR’), one-off initiatives or events (‘EV’) were regarded as unstructured collaborations and therefore marked red and discarded. In cases where the project type could not be confirmed, the datapoint was marked yellow until further revision and ultimately marked green or red and labelled accordingly. If a project was marked red in this step, the row would be considered to fall out of the scope of the project and Step III would automatically be greyed out and marked with a hyphen.

Step III: SDG Scope

Projects whose primary focus aligned with one or more of the four targeted SDGs were marked green, with the corresponding SDG numbers recorded. If more than one SDG was covered by the project, the SDG numbers would be entered in ascending order separated by commas. If the SDG focus was unclear, the datapoint was marked yellow until further review. Projects primarily targeting other SDGs were marked red and excluded from the next stages of this research project. However, in those cases, the projects were retained in the Database, and the main targeted SDG (e.g., 14 or 15) was annotated in the corresponding cell.

This color-coded protocol provided a consistent method for case classification and selection. It enabled systematic filtering and facilitated an overview of existing MSPs working on the different development projects. This data collection is the basis for the next step of the research process which is to conduct a Qualitative Comparative Analysis (QCA) of the MSPs identified in the Database. This methodology aims at analysing MSPs at the operational level and determine which conditions (external and internal factors) explain whether and how these partnerships uptake human rights standards when conducting sustainable development interventions. Nonetheless, the GENESIS Database may have alternative applications, and the data may be useful in the application of other socio-legal methodologies.

³ For the CSV format, which does not show colours, refer only to the text computed in each cell containing the corresponding label for the Type of Partnership, Type of Project, and SDG Scope respectively.

3.1. Aggregated results

The Database contains a total of 3,977 project entries, each one in a single row. The main source of information for this data set was the UN DESA SDG Actions Platform, from which 3,831 projects were extracted, and only the remaining 146 were derived from an exhaustive document analysis of alternative sources related to sustainable development initiatives and partnerships.

Figure 1 illustrates the outcome of the Data Scraping Protocol applied to the full dataset of sustainable development projects. Of all projects reviewed, only 4 per cent (160) were classified as “Checked-In”, meaning that they satisfied all three criteria of the protocol: being implemented by a multistakeholder partnership, constituting a long-term initiative, and having a primary focus aligned with one of the four targeted SDGs (food, health, education, or water). In contrast, 96 per cent of projects (3,817) were classified as “Checked-Out”, having failed to meet at least one of these criteria when assessed sequentially.

This distribution highlights the relative rarity of projects that simultaneously meet the “Type of Partnership”, “Type of Project”, and “SDG Scope” variables requirements necessary for inclusion in the next stages of the GENESIS research, underscoring the selectivity of the protocol and the importance of systematic filtering when identifying MSPs operating within a specific human-rights-relevant scope. The proportion shown in this figure reflects the historical evolution of the UN DESA Platform, which went from being exclusively about partnerships to becoming a portal for all kinds of initiatives, policies, projects, and actions, the majority of which may be implemented by other actors that are not MSPs. Nevertheless, several of the “Checked-Out” projects are being conducted by other types of partnerships working on sustainable development (including corporate partnerships, public-private partnerships, etc.) which, although outside the scope of this particular research project, are evidence of the growth of multistakeholderism and networked arrangements as models of governance and sustainable development management.

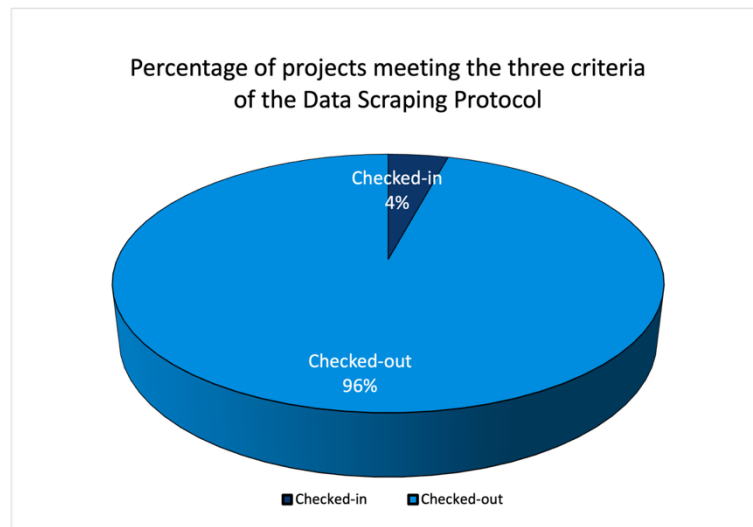


Figure 1: Percentage of projects meeting the three criteria of the Data Scraping Protocol
Source: own creation

When zooming in the 160 projects that were selected after the Protocol application, Figure 2 presents the distribution of MSPs according to their primary sector of activity, as defined by their main SDG focus. The largest number of MSPs operate in the water and sanitation sector (SDG 6), followed by health and well-being (SDG 3), access to quality education (SDG 4), and food and nutrition (SDG 2). In addition to partnerships with a single-sector focus, a smaller number of MSPs work across multiple targeted SDGs, reflecting cross-sectoral approaches to sustainable development. Some partnerships, however, may be multi-sector with other SDGs not targeted by

the project, but the primary focus remains within these four sectors. This distribution suggests that while MSP activity is present across all four domains examined in the GENESIS project, it is particularly concentrated in the water sector, with a total of 81 projects including the ones with multi-SDG mandates.

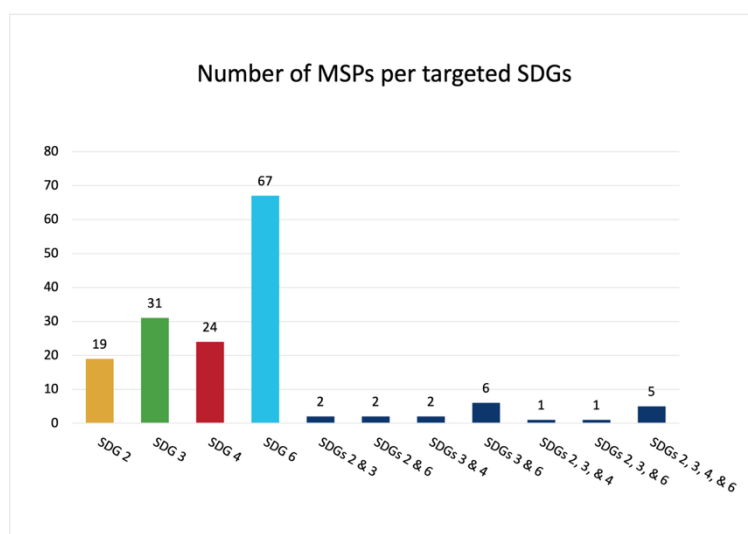


Figure 2: Number of the MSPs working on each of the four SDGs targeted by the GENESIS project
Source: own creation

These aggregated results provide an initial empirical overview of where multistakeholder governance arrangements are most prevalent within the ESCR-related landscape.

3.2. Ethical considerations

The development of the Database and the initial phases of the research were conducted with careful attention to ethical standards, particularly regarding the collection and handling of personal or potentially sensitive data. While compiling the GENESIS Database, certain data points (such as contact names, email addresses, and personal links) were initially extracted from the UN DESA SDG Partnerships Platform. Although this information is publicly accessible through that Platform, it was considered potentially sensitive. For this reason, all personal identifiers were removed from the public version of the database, which is available as an open-access resource. Only information strictly necessary for research purposes (such as project descriptions, partner organizations, and SDG codes) was retained.

Additionally, no direct contact was made with individuals during this stage, and no personal data was processed beyond what was already in the public domain. Future phases of the research may involve outreach to selected MSPs for key informant interviews and document analysis. When that stage begins, appropriate research ethics protocols will follow, including informed consent procedures, data anonymization where required, and secure storage of any sensitive materials.

In line with good data governance practices, the GENESIS project has adopted a Data Management Plan (DMP) in alignment with European Research Council rules and regulations. Accordingly, this open-access Database has been designed to support academic and policy research while safeguarding individual privacy and organizational confidentiality.

Following the DMP, the research team has rigorously ensured that the published dataset meets the FAIR criteria: findable, accessible, interoperable, and reusable. This means that the data presented here is easy to find, for it

uses unique persistent identifiers (PIDs), and is searchable in a public and user-friendly portal. The dataset and metadata presented in the Methodological Sheet of the Database are retrievable and accompanied by a README file to explain access conditions and instructions. Additionally, the Database uses recognized terminologies and structures for users in different disciplines including law, public policy, global governance, international relations, public administration, development studies, among others. Finally, the supporting documents of the Database, including this Report, the Methodological Sheet and the README file are richly described and shared with clear guidelines and licenses, meeting the academic community standards of data reuse and integration.

4. Strengths and limitations

The database was developed to meet the specific scope of this research project, yet it was designed with future usability in mind. Its architecture allows for expansion or modification, whether by incorporating new partnerships, extending the scraping protocol to additional SDGs, or redefining classification filters.

One of the key strengths of the database is its capacity to isolate and examine specific subsets of data across different levels of analysis. Users may apply filters on the columns/variables “Status”, “Type of Partnership”, “Type of Project”, and “SDG Scope” to segment analyses. This feature is essential for applying QCA methodology, which will follow in WP4, but is also valuable for other research methods. The traffic light protocol further enhances usability and automated classification, even if the parameters of each criterion were to be changed.

While significant efforts were made to ensure accuracy and consistency in applying the Data Scraping Protocol, the process inherently involves qualitative judgment, particularly in ambiguous cases. To mitigate this, such cases were flagged for team-based review. Nonetheless, some degree of subjectivity may persist, especially when project descriptions are vague or incomplete.

Although the database includes cross-referenced sources, it may not fully capture the universe of existing MSPs. While the partnerships extracted from the UN DESA SDG Partnerships Platform were supplemented with additional entries identified through documentary search in alternative sources, the list is not exhaustive and can be further expanded. Furthermore, the cut-off date for the inclusion of new projects or partnerships to the Database was 31 October 2025 and the final date for data curation was 15 December 2025, which means that more recently developed partnerships may not be represented. Moreover, existing partnerships already included in the database may have changed in terms of activity, membership composition, or other relevant features after that date.

Finally, while the current version of the database includes metadata related to general project descriptions and thematic focus, it does not yet contain information on partnership outcomes or effectiveness. Such data will be collected for the “Checked-In” MSPs during later stages of the project, but compiling it for the entire dataset would require additional qualitative investigation and resources. As such, the database should be understood as a foundation for further research, rather than as an evaluative tool on its own.

5. Conclusion

This report has outlined the methodology behind the construction of the GENESIS Database on Multistakeholder Partnerships for Sustainable Development, detailing the processes of design, data collection, structuring, and project classification. Built on publicly available data and guided by a predefined Protocol, this database provides a structured and adaptable foundation for future research on multistakeholderism, human rights, and sustainable development. While tailored to the scope of this particular project —focusing on food, health, education, and water— it is designed to be expanded and complemented over time. As such, the database holds

potential value for broader academic and policy-oriented investigations into the role of MSPs in human rights governance and sustainable development.

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